

hard look at all the programs running. If you see something with random character strings as its name... you've guessed it: you're infected by either a virus or spyware. But most viruses and spyware don't give themselves away so easily, and call themselves by decent names.

Talking about running the SCU, if the SCU, the Registry Editor, or your anti-virus program itself doesn't load, you're almost certainly infected.

Keep in mind that a combination of symptoms is much more likely proof that you're infected: rarely does a virus have just one effect. That said, here's a checklist of what to look out for before you press the almighty Scan button on your anti-virus (if the virus hasn't already disabled it!).

0. Your computer takes charge and does things on its own—moving the mouse cursor all by itself, randomly closing and opening windows, showing you messages that say “We’ve got you!” and so forth. If any of this is happening, we don’t even need to tell you that you’re infected!

1. Your computer often stops responding. This is more so a sign of an infection with Windows XP than with earlier versions: Windows 98 used to stop responding often even without infection, so that doesn't mean much!

2. The crashes-and-restarts-on-its own syndrome: this is a pretty good indicator of viral activity on your computer. Of course, it *could* be something else, but if this is happening and your anti-virus is working, why not do a scan anyway?

3. Several apps seem broken. The key word here is “several”: one program not working correctly, like we said, is seldom an indicator of a virus. But if you notice functional anomalies in several applications, it's time to scan.